



Golden finish: GM D. Gukesh was the lodestar of the Chess Olympiad, along with Arjun Erigaisi, for the Indian men's team. Playing on boards one and three respectively in Budapest, they won individual gold medals while guiding the team to a historic first-place finish. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

believe it or not — more than a year. The match began on September 24, 1984, but was stopped on February 10, 1985, after 48 games. Karpov was leading 5-3, but the momentum had shifted to Kasparov, who, therefore, wasn't happy at all with the world chess governing body FIDE's decision, apparently made due to concerns about the players' health.

The rule for that World Championship was that a player who won six games would be the winner. Karpov had taken a 5-0 lead after the 27th game. Then, Kasparov, the younger and hungrier player, staged one of the greatest comebacks in the history of any sport.

However, he had no option but to replay the match in late 1985. This time, FIDE ensured it would not become a never-ending war: it was set to be a best-of-24-games contest, with Karpov as the defending champion, needing only to draw the match.

But Kasparov won 13-11 thanks to his victory with the black pieces in the

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final game. He was 22 then and broke the 25-year-old record of Mikhail Tal. The question is whether Gukesh will surpass Kasparov's record in this World Championship.

The current form of both Gukesh and Ding suggests it is quite probable. The consensus among the world's top chess players is that the Indian teenager is a firm favourite.

Gukesh enters the match after playing exceptional chess over the last two years. It all began with his incredible performance at the Chennai Chess Olympiad in 2022. As the host, India fielded three teams in both the Open and Women's sections, and he was part of an exciting India-2 team.

Expectations were higher for that team than for India's main team. But what Gukesh did on the top board defied expectations. He won his first eight games in a row. It was a remarkable feat, defeating the top player of each country consecutively. This performance is regarded as one of the best in chess history.

At the next Chess Olympiad, two years later in Budapest, Gukesh delivered another spectacular effort on the top board, leading India to a historic gold medal.

Before that, he had won the Candidates Tournament — the qualifying event for the World Championship — in Toronto, where he topped an extremely strong field